

# **A Cross Cultural Comparison of the Importance of Leadership Traits for Effective Low-level and High-level Leaders**

## **Australia and China**

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**ABSTRACT** This study compares perceptions of the importance of 18 traits for effective low-level leaders and high-level leaders. Participants were 84 full-time white-collar employees from Australia and 244 full-time white-collar employees from China. Multivariate analysis of variance revealed cultural differences in terms of which traits are regarded as important for effective leadership. For example, the Australians rated traits that attenuate leader–follower power differences (e.g. friendly and respectful) higher than did the Chinese. Consistent with previous research, traits that were regarded as more important for high-level leaders (e.g. inspirational and visionary) correspond with aspects of charismatic/visionary leadership. The findings indicate that the perceived importance of specific leadership traits is determined partly by culturally endorsed interpersonal norms and partly by the requirements of the leadership role.

**KEY WORDS** • cognitive prototypes • cross cultural • leader-level • leadership

China's recent entry into the World Trade Organization (WTO) has already resulted in an increase in trade agreements between China and many developed nations (e.g.

Australia, the US); foreign direct investments in China are estimated to total US\$60 billion in 2006 (*South China Post*, 2006). The increase in trade between China and developed

nations will inevitably lead to increased interactions between personnel from China and the developed nations. These personnel, especially expatriate managers, need to be aware of cultural differences and similarities in leadership prototypes in order to perform effectively, because people tend to perceive behaviour that differs from their own norms as negative (House et al., 2004; Rubin et al., 1994).

Leadership is a major component of the social fabric of many organizations (Lord et al., 1986), and prototypical perceptions of effective leadership represent an important topic of investigation for researchers (Hackman and Lawler, 1971; Hunt, 1991; Peterson, 1985). Perceptions of leadership are what followers act on and, therefore, such perceptions can impact the outcomes of the leadership process (Bennett, 1977; Gerstner and Day, 1994). Leader acceptance and effectiveness may depend on leader attributes and behaviours being congruent with the endorsed implicit leadership theories of followers (Cronshaw and Lord, 1987; House et al., 1999). Furthermore, certain characteristics of a culture may render specific leadership characteristics and styles acceptable and effective (House et al., 2004). For example, a leader who adopts an autocratic style may be more accepted and effective in a high power distance culture (e.g. China) than in a low power distance culture (e.g. Australia).

Although studies have examined cultural differences in leadership traits (e.g. Brodbeck et al., 2000; Den Hartog et al., 1999; Gerstner and Day, 1994; Helgstrand and Stuhlmacher, 1999), there are important issues that remain to be addressed, especially with regard to comparisons between China and an Anglo-Saxon culture such as Australia. The largest study thus far, project GLOBE (House et al., 2004), involved data from approximately 17,000 managers from 951 organizations in 62 societies around the world. However, with project GLOBE, middle managers were asked to rate leadership traits

that would help or hinder a person in being an outstanding leader. As noted by Den Hartog et al. (1999), a possible limitation is that when making their ratings, middle managers are most likely to focus on leaders at the upper echelon. Although Den Hartog et al. (1999) specifically asked respondents to consider traits for top-level leaders and for lower-level leaders, their data were based exclusively on a Dutch sample. We contribute to the literature by providing a cross cultural comparison of the importance of various leadership traits for effective low-level and high-level leaders.

## Leadership Traits and Culture

There is an extensive body of literature on the influence of various cognitive structures (e.g. cognitive prototypes, implicit theories of leadership, self-schemas) on leader behaviour descriptions (e.g. Phillips and Lord, 1981; Rush et al., 1977), leader-subordinate relationships (Engle and Lord, 1997), and perceptions of leadership behaviours in both laboratory settings (e.g. Cronshaw and Lord, 1987) and actual organizational settings (Maurer and Lord, 1991). Cognitive prototypes appear to be a central component of implicit leadership theories (Lord et al., 1982) and provide an abstract standard, or expectation, against which actual leaders can be compared. Cognitive prototypes thus influence perceptions of leadership as well as reactions to leadership, because interpretations of and reactions to leadership depend on the type of prototype that is evoked (Lord et al., 1984). Furthermore, it is important for leaders to be aware of followers' expectations given the reciprocity of influence in the leader-follower relationship (Hollander, 1992).

According to Lord and Maher's (1991) 'recognition model', an important determinant of being perceived as an effective leader is the congruence between the follower's pre-existing notions of the ideal characteristics of an effective leader and his or her perceptions

of the leader's actual characteristics. The better the match between ideal and actual characteristics, the more likely it is that the leader will receive credit for favourable work outcomes and therefore attain the social power vital for effective leadership (Cronshaw and Lord, 1987; Hollander and Julian, 1969; Shaw, 1990). Although there is evidence that some leadership traits and practices are endorsed universally, there is also evidence that the enactment of these traits varies across cultures (Den Hartog et al., 1999; House et al., 2004). For instance, although leaders in Australia and New Zealand are expected to be egalitarian, Australian leaders are expected to be more socially oriented and less task-oriented than their New Zealand counterparts (Trevor-Roberts et al., 2003). Leaders who are required to interact with a diverse set of followers, or who work in a foreign environment, need to recognize that notions of what constitutes ideal leadership may vary culturally (Shaw, 1990).

Societies compel their members to desire a set of socially approved symbols of success (e.g. big house, expensive car, high-ranking job), which are congruent with societal values (e.g. wealth, power) (Mernot, 1938). Furthermore, people pursue goals because goal attainment implies that they possess those qualities that are socially desirable (Machr and Nicholls, 1980). Consequently, leaders might favour certain leadership practices because such practices might be perceived as indicators of certain socially desirable characteristics. For instance, in cultures that value decisiveness and hierarchy, leaders might prefer to be autocratic, and subordinates might prefer to be loyal and obedient. Conversely, in cultures that value egalitarianism, leaders might prefer to be consultative, and subordinates might prefer to be challenging and outspoken.

The perceptual processes of followers are shaped to a large extent by their cultural background and influence their perceptions

of leadership (Hofstede, 1980; Shaw, 1990). Culture can be regarded as 'software of the mind' (Hofstede, 1980) in that it provides members of a collective with shared cognitive structures (e.g. cognitive prototypes, implicit theories) that reflect shared ideologies and values (Hunt et al., 1990), and influence interpretations of specific behaviours (Gioia and Poole, 1984; Lord and Maher, 1991). Consequently, the acceptability of a particular leadership style is likely to depend largely on the cultural background of the followers.

There is evidence of cross cultural differences and similarities in the leadership prototypicality of various traits, indicating that some traits may be endorsed universally as prototypical of effective leaders, whereas the endorsement of other traits may be culturally contingent:

- 1 Gerstner and Day (1994) found the leadership prototypicality of traits to be related strongly to three of Hofstede's (1980) cultural dimensions. Cross cultural similarities in leadership prototypes were also found by Gerstner and Day (1994). Specifically, the trait 'goal-oriented' was the second most important prototypical trait for effective business leaders.
- 2 The findings of Project GLOBE (House et al., 2004) suggest that some traits (e.g. visionary, intelligent, trustworthy, and decisive) are endorsed universally as positive attributes for a leader to possess, whereas the endorsement of other traits is more culturally contingent (e.g. compassionate, domineering, orderly, and risk taker).
- 3 Helgstrand and Stuhlmacher (1999) found that American and Danish students saw feminine leaders as most collegial, and feminine-individualistic leaders as most effective.
- 4 Brodbeck et al. (2000) found that leadership prototypes differed systematically with the general cultural values held by

managers and employees in 10 different regions of Europe. Some traits (e.g. integrity, performance-oriented, team integrator, and visionary), however, were seen as facilitating outstanding leadership in all of the regions (e.g. integrity and visionary), except for France.

## **Chinese and Australian Leadership**

China's cultural tradition is founded on Confucian values, which still provide the basis for the norms of Chinese interpersonal behaviour (Shenkar and Ronen, 1987). According to Hofstede and Bond (1988), one of the key principles of Confucianism is that social stability is dependent on unequal relationships. Confucianism emphasizes hierarchy and contends that each individual should be conscious of his or her position in the social system. Although Chinese culture may be changing, with wealth increasingly becoming the paramount value for Chinese people, some key elements of the culture (e.g. respect for authority, collectivism) remain unchanged (Lew, 1998). In short, there may be sound reasons to expect the Chinese to endorse a different set of leadership traits to that of other cultures.

Tung (1988) argued that China would score low on individualism because of the high value the Chinese place on the family/referent group and the socialistic influence of Communism. Research has supported Tung's (1988) claim in that collectivistic values have been shown to be dominant in China (e.g. Dorfman and Howell, 1988; Ralston et al., 1996). It can also be argued that China would score high on power distance because of the Confucian emphasis on hierarchy. Along these lines, the beliefs of Chinese managers have been found to be more autocratic than those of managers from developed countries, especially regarding sharing information with subordinates and participative decision-making (Redding and Casey, 1986).

In contrast to the Chinese, Australians tend to prefer managerial practices that are egalitarian and consultative (Clark and McCabe, 1970; Robbins et al., 1994), which is consistent with their preference for low power distance (Hofstede, 1980). Australian leadership is distinct because of its emphasis on egalitarianism and individualism, and Australian leaders are expected to maintain the perception of equality (i.e. mateship) with their followers (Trevor-Roberts et al., 2003). Indeed, a prerequisite for leadership success in Australia is appearing as ordinary (Horne, 1987). Australians tend to play down inequalities and are not fearful or in awe of their bosses (Robbins et al., 1994), or other authority figures. For example, Australian students have been shown to prefer an assertive style (e.g. they address the lecturer by first name, maintain direct eye contact, and speak loudly) when complaining to a lecturer about their grades (Gallois et al., 1992).

Individualism–collectivism has been shown to impact managerial perceptions, attitudes and behaviours (Neelankavil et al., 2000). Hong Kong Chinese managers who migrated to Australia reported that they had to adapt to a smaller power distance between supervisors and subordinates, as well as to a more direct and participatory communication style (Mak, 1998). Australian middle managers perceived participative leadership to be more important for outstanding leadership than did middle managers from China, Hong Kong and Taiwan (Den Hartog et al., 1999).

There are additional reasons to expect differences between Australians and Chinese in terms of the importance placed on different leadership traits. First, compared to Chinese, Australians are less concerned with uncertainty avoidance (House et al., 2004), and thus may place less emphasis on formalization and standardization. Accordingly, they may expect more innovative or less orderly behaviours from their leaders (Den Hartog et al., 1999). Second, in individualistic/low

power distance countries (e.g. Australia), managers typically create job-based work designs founded on individual initiative and responsibility. In contrast, in collectivistic/high power distance countries (e.g. China), managers prefer team-based work organizations with strong control by supervisors, in which team-level quality measures and tools are used to manage quality (Earley and Erez, 1997). Third, there is evidence that Chinese managers do not view communication as especially important for effective leadership (Neelankavil et al., 2000).

On the basis of these findings, we expect that Australians and Chinese will differ in the importance that they place on different leadership traits. Specifically, we hypothesize that:

*H1a:* Australians will regard being non-bossy, communicative, friendly, humorous, participative, and respectful as more important for effective leaders than will the Chinese because these traits involve behaviours that attenuate leader–follower power differences.

*H1b:* The Chinese will regard concern for subordinates' interests, integrating, modest, and team-player traits as more important for effective leadership than will the Australians because these traits enhance a collective orientation to work.

## High-level versus Low-level Leaders

It is apparent that the roles and responsibilities of leaders vary with hierarchical level. Specifically, high-level leadership is more strategic in nature (e.g. developing and promoting a vision, thinking about organizational structure and policies, allocating resources, public relations). Conversely, low-level leadership is constrained by the decisions made by high-level leadership and is primarily concerned with issues that are more immediate, less complex, and which necessitate closer involvement with followers, such as staffing and scheduling work, as well as structuring and monitoring the work activ-

ities of followers (Yukl, 2002). Put another way, high-level leadership is concerned with ends more than means, whereas low-level leadership is concerned with means more than ends (Etzioni, 1961). Not surprisingly then, the behaviour of high-level leaders and low-level leaders has been shown to differ both qualitatively (Antonakis and Atwater, 2002; Hemphill, 1959) and quantitatively (Lowe et al., 1996; Mintzberg, 1973).

Given that leaders at different hierarchical levels perform different functions, followers are likely to expect different things from them (Lord and Maher, 1991). Consequently, we propose that different leader traits will be regarded as important for high-level leaders and low-level leaders. There is evidence (i.e. Den Hartog et al., 1999) that traits associated with transformational leadership (e.g. courageous, diplomatic, innovative, inspirational, and visionary) are seen as more important for high-level leaders than for low-level leaders, while traits associated with daily operations and interacting with followers (e.g. concern for subordinates' interests, orderly, participative, and team-builder) are seen as more important for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders. The following hypotheses are therefore proposed:

*H2a:* Traits associated with transformational leadership (i.e. confidence builder, courageous, diplomatic, innovative, inspirational, persuasive, and visionary) will be regarded as more important for high-level leaders than for low-level leaders.

*H2b:* Traits associated with daily operations such as structuring and organizing the work of followers (e.g. concern for subordinates' interests, orderly, participative, and team-player) as well as those associated with directly interacting with followers (i.e. friendly, humorous, and respectful) will be regarded as more important for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders.

## Method

### Samples

Two Australian samples were used. One rated the importance of the traits for low-level leaders (referred to as low-level sample), while the other rated the importance of the traits for high-level leaders (referred to as high-level sample). Each sample consisted of 42 full-time white-collar employees who worked in a range of occupations (e.g. administration, engineering, and finance). The low-level sample comprised 24 males and 18 females with an average age of 31.6 years ( $sd = 11.8$ ) and average work experience of 13.0 years ( $sd = 10.4$ ). The high-level sample comprised 27 males and 15 females with an average age of 38.6 years ( $sd = 8.4$ ) and average work experience of 18.2 years ( $sd = 8.7$ ).

Similarly, two Chinese samples were used, each sample consisting of 122 full-time white-collar employees who worked in a range of occupations (e.g. administration, advertising, and marketing). The low-level sample comprised 51 males and 71 females with an average age of 35.5 years ( $sd = 9.4$ ) and average work experience of 15.3 years ( $sd = 9.8$ ). The high-level sample comprised 58 males and 64 females with an average age of 30.8 years ( $sd = 9.7$ ) and average work experience of 9.7 years ( $sd = 9.8$ ).

Participants were selected from several organizations in Australia and in China so that, despite the small sample size, the findings could be generalized and also to avoid the confounding influence of organizational effects, because organizational factors such as a dysfunctional management team (e.g. dishonest) can render the importance of certain traits (e.g. trustworthy) more salient for employees.

### Measures

A total of 18 traits were selected, of which the following were obtained from Den Hartog et al. (1999): inspirational, innovative, commu-

nicative, visionary, concern for subordinates' interest, modest, persuasive, orderly, integrating, participative, confidence builder, courageous, diplomatic, and team-player. The trait 'bossy' was obtained from GLOBE's Autocratic scale (Brodbeck et al., 2000), on the assumption that it might be particularly relevant to the Chinese sample because of their preference for high power distance. An additional three traits that we thought might be relevant to demonstrating cultural differences were also used: friendly, humorous, and respectful. These traits were thought to be especially relevant to Australians because of their preference for egalitarianism.

### Procedure

Employees were informed that the study was about their opinions on the importance of various characteristics for effective leadership. They were also advised that participation was voluntary, with confidentiality and anonymity assured. Participants completed the questionnaire at their workplace on company time either individually, in pairs, or in small groups, depending on the requirements of the organization.

A Chinese (i.e. Mandarin) version of the questionnaire was developed using back-translation (Brislin, 1983). The translators were asked to pay special attention to the conceptual equivalence of the Chinese and English versions of the questionnaire, because back-translation does not guarantee conceptual equivalence.

Similar to prior work on leadership traits (e.g. Gerstner and Day, 1994; House et al., 2004), participants were asked the following question: 'In your opinion, how important are the following characteristics for an effective low-level leader?' The same question was asked with reference to a high-level leader. Participants rated the importance of the traits on a five-point scale: 1 = not at all important, 2 = a little important, 3 = fairly important, 4 = very important, and 5 = absolutely necessary.

**Table 1** Results of the multivariate analysis of variance on importance ratings for the leadership traits

|                                               | Wilks' $\lambda$ | F    | p    | partial $\eta^2$ |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------------|------|------|------------------|
| Culture <sup>a</sup>                          | .63              | 10.0 | .000 | .370             |
| Leader-level <sup>b</sup>                     | .66              | 8.7  | .000 | .338             |
| Culture $\times$ Leader-level                 | .79              | 4.5  | .000 | .210             |
| Culture <sup>a</sup>                          | .64              | 9.5  | .000 | .360             |
| Leader-level <sup>b</sup>                     | .66              | 8.6  | .000 | .337             |
| Gender <sup>c</sup>                           | .94              | 1.1  | .371 | .060             |
| Culture $\times$ Leader-level                 | .80              | 4.3  | .000 | .203             |
| Culture $\times$ Gender                       | .93              | 1.3  | .158 | .074             |
| Leader-level $\times$ Gender                  | .93              | 1.3  | .167 | .073             |
| Culture $\times$ Leader-level $\times$ Gender | .92              | 1.4  | .109 | .079             |

<sup>a</sup>  $N = 84$  Australian and 244 Chinese.

<sup>b</sup>  $N = 164$  Low-level and 164 High-level.

<sup>c</sup>  $N = 160$  male and 168 female.

## Results

A two-way (culture  $\times$  leader-level) Multivariate Analysis of Variance (MANOVA) was conducted to test the hypotheses. As shown in the top section of Table 1, significant multivariate effects were found for culture, leader-level, and culture  $\times$  leader-level. Significant interaction effects were found for the traits bossy, confidence builder, courageous, inspirational, team-player, and visionary. These interaction effects will be addressed when considering each of these traits in relation to the hypotheses.

### Cultural Differences

As can be seen in Table 2, the Australians rated the traits bossy, communicative, friendly, humorous, participative, and respectful significantly higher than did the Chinese. With the exception of the trait bossy, these findings support Hypothesis 1a. The Chinese rated the traits integrating and modest significantly higher than did the Australians. Non-significant cultural differences were found for concern for subordinates' interests and team-player. These findings partially support Hypothesis 1b.

As shown in Table 3, the significant interaction for the trait bossy occurred because the Australians, contrary to what was hypothesized, rated this trait higher than did the Chinese, but only for low-level leaders. The significant interaction for team-player occurred for the same reason.

### Leader-level Differences

As shown in Table 4, the traits courageous, innovative, inspirational, persuasive, and visionary were rated significantly higher for high-level leaders than for low-level leaders. Non-significant differences were found for confidence builder and diplomatic. Taken together, these findings provide overall support for Hypothesis 2a. Significant interaction effects were found for the traits confidence builder, courageous, inspirational, and visionary. The interaction effect for confidence builder was because the Australians, as expected, rated it higher for high-level managers than for low-level managers, whereas the Chinese, contrary to what was expected, rated it lower for high-level managers than for low-level managers. The interaction effect for the traits courageous, inspirational, and visionary was the result of a more pro-



**Table 2** Follow-up univariate analyses of variances for the leadership traits by culture

|                       | Australian <sup>a</sup><br>M (SD) | Chinese <sup>b</sup><br>M (SD) | F    | Sig. | Partial $\eta^2$ |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------|------|------|------------------|
| Bossy                 | 1.68 (0.88)                       | 1.47 (0.82)                    | 3.9  | .049 | .012             |
| Communicative         | 4.54 (0.67)                       | 3.64 (0.85)                    | 77.7 | .000 | .193             |
| Concern for followers | 3.96 (0.88)                       | 3.91 (0.85)                    | 0.3  | .617 | .001             |
| Confidence builder    | 4.15 (0.78)                       | 3.84 (0.86)                    | 9.0  | .003 | .027             |
| Courageous            | 3.57 (0.99)                       | 3.86 (1.00)                    | 5.6  | .018 | .017             |
| Diplomatic            | 3.82 (0.81)                       | 3.78 (0.88)                    | 0.2  | .695 | .000             |
| Friendly              | 3.82 (0.95)                       | 3.32 (0.93)                    | 18.1 | .000 | .053             |
| Humorous              | 3.10 (0.93)                       | 2.76 (0.95)                    | 7.9  | .005 | .024             |
| Innovative            | 3.38 (0.85)                       | 3.57 (1.08)                    | 2.1  | .146 | .007             |
| Inspirational         | 3.76 (0.98)                       | 3.84 (1.03)                    | 0.4  | .554 | .001             |
| Integrating           | 3.65 (0.81)                       | 3.87 (0.85)                    | 4.2  | .041 | .013             |
| Modest                | 2.90 (0.91)                       | 3.20 (0.93)                    | 6.7  | .010 | .020             |
| Orderly               | 3.57 (0.84)                       | 3.97 (0.91)                    | 12.3 | .001 | .037             |
| Participative         | 3.95 (0.85)                       | 3.51 (0.90)                    | 16.0 | .000 | .047             |
| Persuasive            | 3.75 (0.94)                       | 3.92 (0.81)                    | 2.5  | .116 | .008             |
| Respectful            | 4.36 (0.77)                       | 4.03 (0.90)                    | 8.9  | .003 | .027             |
| Team-player           | 4.13 (1.00)                       | 3.91 (0.88)                    | 3.8  | .053 | .011             |
| Visionary             | 3.67 (1.10)                       | 3.92 (0.98)                    | 5.1  | .025 | .015             |

<sup>a</sup>  $N = 84$ , <sup>b</sup>  $N = 244$ .

nounced leader-level effect for these three traits among the Australians.

Non-significant leader-level differences were found for the traits concern for subordinates' interests, orderly, and participative. The trait team-player was rated significantly higher for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders. Overall, these findings do not support Hypothesis 2b. It is notable, however, that the leader-level differences proposed in Hypothesis 2b were in the hypothesized direction for all of the traits among the Australians and for all but one of the traits (i.e. orderly) among the Chinese.

A three-way (gender  $\times$  culture  $\times$  leader-level) MANOVA was conducted to examine the effects of gender on ratings of the leadership traits given that there is evidence (e.g. Sczesny et al., 2004) that gender influences perceptions of leadership. The findings from this analysis are presented in the lower

section of Table 1, and show a non-significant multivariate effect for gender, a non-significant multivariate effect for the gender  $\times$  culture interaction, a non-significant multivariate effect for the gender  $\times$  leader-level interaction, and a non-significant multivariate effect for the gender  $\times$  culture  $\times$  leader-level interaction. The gender of the participants therefore did not significantly influence the ratings of the leadership traits.

# Discussion

The results indicate that cross cultural differences exist in traits considered important for effective leadership. Taken together, the findings support the notion that cultural background influences the perceived importance of various traits with regard to effective leadership. Australian culture is renowned for its emphasis on egalitarianism, whereas



**Table 3** Mean ratings for the leadership traits by culture and leader-level

|                       | Australian<br>Low-level <sup>a</sup><br>M (SD) | Chinese<br>High-level <sup>b</sup><br>M (SD) | Low-level <sup>c</sup><br>M (SD) | High-level <sup>d</sup><br>M (SD) |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Bossy                 | 1.83 (1.03)                                    | 1.52 (0.67)                                  | 1.38 (0.65)                      | 1.57 (0.95)                       |
| Communicative         | 4.43 (0.77)                                    | 4.64 (0.53)                                  | 3.58 (0.82)                      | 3.70 (0.87)                       |
| Concern for followers | 4.10 (0.79)                                    | 3.83 (0.96)                                  | 3.93 (0.85)                      | 3.89 (0.86)                       |
| Confidence builder    | 4.00 (0.80)                                    | 4.31 (0.75)                                  | 3.90 (0.87)                      | 3.77 (0.86)                       |
| Courageous            | 3.19 (1.10)                                    | 3.95 (0.73)                                  | 3.82 (0.99)                      | 3.91 (1.01)                       |
| Diplomatic            | 3.69 (0.78)                                    | 3.95 (0.83)                                  | 3.82 (0.93)                      | 3.74 (0.83)                       |
| Friendly              | 3.95 (0.94)                                    | 3.69 (0.95)                                  | 3.41 (0.91)                      | 3.23 (0.95)                       |
| Humorous              | 3.19 (0.97)                                    | 3.00 (0.88)                                  | 2.91 (1.04)                      | 2.61 (0.83)                       |
| Innovative            | 3.24 (0.93)                                    | 3.52 (0.74)                                  | 3.30 (1.08)                      | 3.84 (1.02)                       |
| Inspirational         | 3.29 (1.04)                                    | 4.24 (0.62)                                  | 3.77 (1.06)                      | 3.90 (1.00)                       |
| Integrating           | 3.52 (0.83)                                    | 3.79 (0.78)                                  | 3.93 (0.80)                      | 3.81 (0.90)                       |
| Modest                | 2.93 (0.95)                                    | 2.88 (0.89)                                  | 3.35 (0.85)                      | 3.06 (0.98)                       |
| Orderly               | 3.71 (0.81)                                    | 3.43 (0.86)                                  | 3.91 (0.88)                      | 4.02 (0.94)                       |
| Participative         | 4.00 (0.88)                                    | 3.90 (0.82)                                  | 3.65 (0.82)                      | 3.37 (0.95)                       |
| Persuasive            | 3.55 (0.97)                                    | 3.95 (0.88)                                  | 3.85 (0.76)                      | 3.98 (0.86)                       |
| Respectful            | 4.38 (0.80)                                    | 4.33 (0.75)                                  | 4.11 (0.80)                      | 3.95 (1.00)                       |
| Team-player           | 4.48 (0.71)                                    | 3.79 (1.14)                                  | 3.96 (0.78)                      | 3.86 (0.98)                       |
| Visionary             | 2.93 (1.00)                                    | 4.40 (0.67)                                  | 3.57 (0.93)                      | 4.27 (0.90)                       |

<sup>a</sup>  $n = 42$ , <sup>b</sup>  $n = 42$ , <sup>c</sup>  $n = 122$ , <sup>d</sup>  $n = 122$ .

Chinese culture is renowned for being authority oriented. The findings are consistent with these cultural characteristics in that the Australians rated traits that attenuate power differences between leaders and followers (i.e. communicative, friendly, humorous, participative, and respectful) more highly than did the Chinese. Additionally, the Chinese rated the traits integrating and modest higher than did the Australians, which is consistent with collectivism and Confucian values.

The results also revealed cross cultural similarities in traits regarded as important for effective leaders: non-significant cultural differences were found for the traits concern for followers' interests, diplomatic, innovative, inspirational, persuasive, and team-player. Another index of cross cultural consistency in

terms of the importance of various traits is that of the 18 traits, only six had significant culture  $\times$  leader-level interactions. Furthermore, of these six, only two (i.e. bossy and confidence builder) had crossover interactions. Moreover, the interaction effect for bossy is negligible because this trait was clearly the least important trait among both groups for both levels of leader. The interaction effect for confidence builder was a result of the Australians rating it higher for high-level managers than for low-level managers, whereas the Chinese rated it lower for high-level managers than for low-level managers. The four other interaction effects (i.e. courageous, inspirational, team-player, and visionary) were the result of a more pronounced leader-level effect in one of the groups.

Clear differences in the importance of

**Table 4** Follow-up univariate analyses of variances for the leadership traits by leader-level

|                       | Low-level <sup>a</sup> | High-level <sup>b</sup> |      |      |                  |
|-----------------------|------------------------|-------------------------|------|------|------------------|
|                       | M (SD)                 | M (SD)                  | F    | Sig. | Partial $\eta^2$ |
| Bossy                 | 1.49 (0.79)            | 1.55 (0.89)             | 0.3  | .565 | .001             |
| Communicative         | 3.80 (0.89)            | 3.94 (0.90)             | 2.6  | .107 | .008             |
| Concern for followers | 3.97 (0.83)            | 3.88 (0.89)             | 1.8  | .176 | .006             |
| Confidence builder    | 3.93 (0.85)            | 3.91 (0.86)             | 0.7  | .403 | .002             |
| Courageous            | 3.66 (1.04)            | 3.92 (0.95)             | 11.8 | .001 | .035             |
| Diplomatic            | 3.79 (0.89)            | 3.79 (0.83)             | 0.7  | .410 | .002             |
| Friendly              | 3.55 (0.94)            | 3.35 (0.97)             | 3.5  | .062 | .011             |
| Humorous              | 2.98 (1.02)            | 2.71 (0.86)             | 4.2  | .041 | .013             |
| Innovative            | 3.28 (1.04)            | 3.76 (0.96)             | 10.7 | .001 | .032             |
| Inspirational         | 3.65 (1.07)            | 3.99 (0.93)             | 18.7 | .000 | .055             |
| Integrating           | 3.83 (0.83)            | 3.80 (0.87)             | 0.4  | .515 | .001             |
| Modest                | 3.24 (0.89)            | 3.01 (0.96)             | 2.2  | .141 | .007             |
| Orderly               | 3.86 (0.86)            | 3.87 (0.95)             | 0.6  | .449 | .002             |
| Participative         | 3.74 (0.85)            | 3.51 (0.94)             | 2.8  | .093 | .009             |
| Persuasive            | 3.77 (0.82)            | 3.98 (0.87)             | 6.3  | .012 | .019             |
| Respectful            | 4.18 (0.81)            | 4.05 (0.95)             | 0.8  | .358 | .003             |
| Team-player           | 4.09 (0.79)            | 3.84 (1.02)             | 12.0 | .001 | .036             |
| Visionary             | 3.41 (0.98)            | 4.30 (0.85)             | 91.6 | .000 | .220             |

<sup>a</sup>  $n = 164$ , <sup>b</sup>  $n = 164$ .

various traits for low-level leaders and high-level leaders were found. Both the Australians and the Chinese regarded it more important for high-level leaders than for low-level leaders to be courageous, innovative, inspirational, persuasive, and visionary. These traits can be linked to strategic leadership in that such leaders need to create a vision that usually involves insight and risk-taking, and a need to inspire others to undertake the risks generally associated with visionary leadership. Both cultural groups also regarded it more important for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders to be friendly, humorous, and a team-player. These traits can be linked to the idea that that socio-emotional leadership is more important for low-level leaders because of their greater and closer involvement with followers.

The leader-level findings from this study

closely resemble those of Den Hartog et al.'s (1999) Dutch sample. Together with the findings from Brodbeck et al.'s (2000) European samples, these studies show that the traits that are regarded as important for leadership are determined partly by the requirements of the leadership role and partly by culturally endorsed interpersonal norms. For example, the Australians regarded communicative as very important for effective leaders regardless of the leader's hierarchical level, whereas they regarded being friendly and humorous as more important for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders. Similarly, the Chinese regarded being modest as very important for effective leaders regardless of the leader's hierarchical level, whereas they regarded being friendly and humorous as more important for low-level leaders than for high-level leaders. These differences demonstrate the

combined effects of cultural values and job requirements on the importance placed on different traits for effective leaders.

A possible alternative and supplementary explanation for the differences in importance ratings between the two cultures is a difference in response styles to Likert scales. Specifically, collectivists (e.g. Chinese) are less likely than are individualists (e.g. Australians) to use the extreme points in a scale (Chen et al., 1995; Chun et al., 1974). However, the response style argument is not supported by the data obtained in this study in that 27.8% of the Australian responses were extreme (i.e. either a 1 or a 5 on the scale) compared to 28.1% of the Chinese responses.

This study has some limitations that warrant mentioning. First, the sample sizes were small, thereby limiting the generalizability of the findings. Another limitation is that participants rated a large number of traits and so it was difficult to ascertain from the findings which of the traits is regarded as paramount for effective leadership. Future research should consider measuring the relative importance of various traits so as to get a more detailed picture of the traits associated with effective leaders.

Future research might also examine the effects of other variables on the importance placed on leadership traits. For example, do certain situational factors (e.g. environmental uncertainty) increase the saliency of some traits (e.g. courageous)? The consistent message from this and other studies is that leaders need to recognize the importance of cultural values and practices, and thereby adapt to different cultural expectations in order to be perceived as acceptable and effective. Furthermore, leaders must be cognizant of the different requirements associated with low-level and high-level leadership and need to tailor their style to suit the different roles.

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## Résumé

### Comparaison transculturelle de l'importance des caractéristiques du leadership par rapport à l'efficacité des grands et petits leaders : l'Australie et la Chine (Gian Casimir et David A Waldman)

Cette étude compare les perceptions de l'importance accordée à 18 caractéristiques d'efficacité pour grands et petits leaders. Trois cent vingt-huit employés de bureau à plein temps ont participé à cette étude, dont 84 Australiens et 244 Chinois. Une analyse à variables multiples des différences a révélé des spécificités culturelles dans le choix des caractéristiques considérées comme importantes pour diriger avec efficacité. Par exemple, les Australiens ont davantage insisté que les Chinois sur les caractéristiques liées au fait d'atténuer les rapports de pouvoir entre leader et exécutant (par ex., cordial et respectueux). Confortant en cela de précédentes recherches, les caractéristiques considérées comme les plus importantes pour les grands leaders (par ex., stimulant et visionnaire) correspondent aux aspects du leadership charismatique/visionnaire. Les résultats indiquent que la perception de l'importance de caractéristiques propres au leadership est déterminée en partie par l'intégration des normes culturelles interpersonnelles et, en partie, par les exigences du rôle de leader.

## 摘要

对于低水平和高水平有效领导者领导力特征重要性的跨文化比较：澳大利亚和中国

Gian Casimir and David A Waldman

本项研究比较了对于低水平和高水平有效领导者的18项特征的重要性的不同认识。参与研究的人员有来自澳大利亚的84名全职白领和来自中国的244名全职白领。多元方差分析揭示了，在识别什么特征是有效领导的重要特征上存在文化差异。比如，澳大利亚人比中国人更看重那些减小领导与下属之间权力差距的特征（比如，友好和礼貌）。那些被认为对于高水平领导者更重要的特征（比如，充满灵感和富有远见）与魅力型/愿景型领导是对应的，这一点与以前的研究发现是一致的。研究结果指出，具体的领导特征重要性的认知一部分是由打上文化烙印的人际关系规范所决定，一部分是由领导的角色要求所决定。